Students stall at choosing a fund, not at fees. A neutral side-by-side view could fix it.

Revolut investing teardown and PRD · Muhammad Ghazwan · October 2026

Situation	Revolut puts investing inside the bank app, and cheap index funds are open to EEA customers.
Complication	Students who want a long-term fund search “S&P 500”, see three near-identical funds, and leave.
Question	How can Revolut help a first-time student choose with confidence, without giving advice?
Answer	Show the facts it already holds side by side, in plain words, with no ranking.

Why I believe this

1. **5 of 6 students** struggled to pick between similar funds; both who had never invested left the app at that screen.
2. **The data already exists.** Cost, size and a risk score sit on each fund’s page, just never side by side.
3. **Fees and sign-up were not the problem.** Nobody was surprised by a fee and nobody quit at sign-up.

Next step: test a clickable prototype with 5 to 8 students before any build, then a controlled experiment.

Evidence: app walkthrough (45 screens) and 6 student interviews, Oct 2026. Early evidence, not proof.

I tested four guesses with an app walkthrough and six student interviews, using a rule set in advance.

1

Walk the app

45 logged screens, from the Invest tab to the order screen (stopped before Submit).

2

Write four guesses

Fees surprise people; funds are hard to find or choose; the free-trade rule confuses; sign-up makes people quit.

3

Interview six students

About past behaviour, not opinions, then a think-aloud task in the app where possible (4 of 6).

4

Apply the rule

Group every friction moment, count who raised it, keep only what passes.

5

Write the fix

A one-page PR/FAQ first, then the PRD with metrics and guardrails.

WHO I SPOKE TO

2	2	2
never invested	started recently	invest regularly

DECISION RULE, WRITTEN BEFORE INTERVIEW ONE

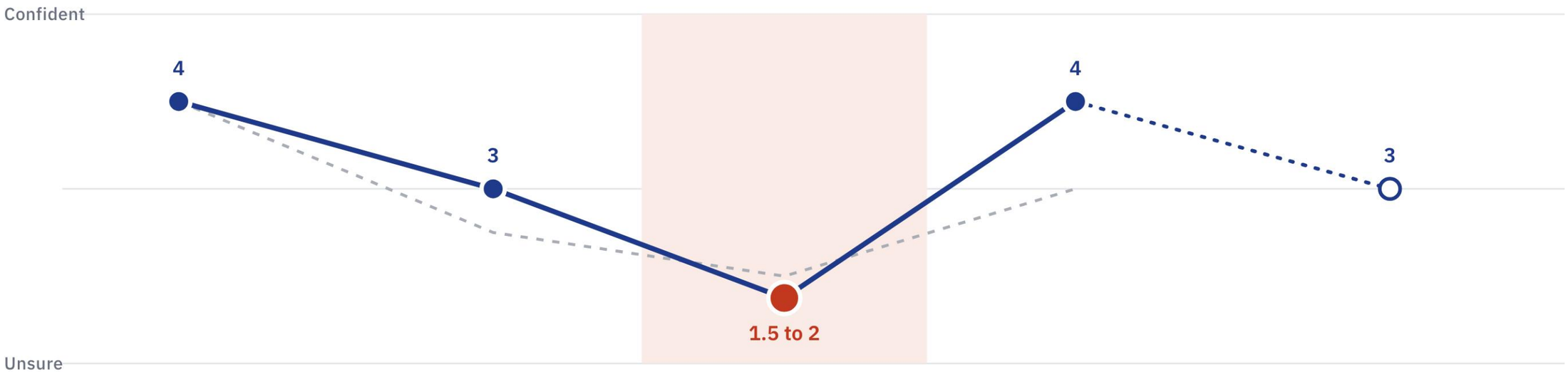
A problem counts only if 3 of 6 raise it unprompted, or 2 say it made them stop.

This stopped me picking the problem I expected. It ruled out fees, my first guess.

Method: Mom Test interviews; Amazon PR/FAQ; jobs to be done. Interviews 3 to 6 recorded with consent and transcribed with AI, then checked.

Students lose the most confidence at one step: choosing between near-identical funds.

How confident students felt at each step of a first fund purchase, from six interviews, against my guess before them.



Arrive
Invest tab sits inside the bank app: easy

Sign up
Extra steps and forms. Annoying; nobody quit

Choose a fund
Three S&P 500 funds, nothing to compare them
Both non-investors left here

Place the order
Simple; costs shown before Submit

Afterwards
Price swings, checking often (one student)

What students described — My guess before the interviews — Scale 1 (unsure) to 5 (confident)

Source: 6 student interviews and an app walkthrough, October 2026. Early evidence, not proof.

Five of six students struggled to pick between similar funds. None were surprised by fees.

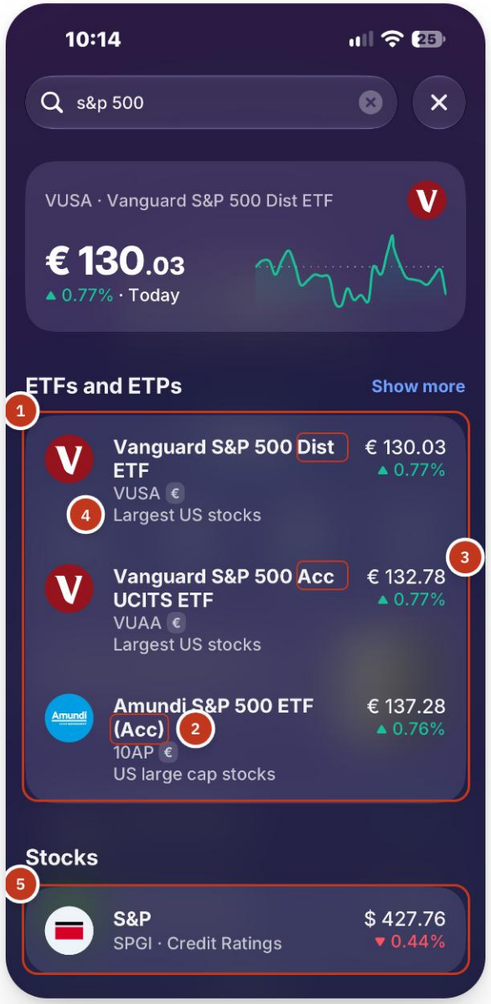
A problem counted only if 3 of 6 raised it, or 2 stopped because of it.

	Never invested		Started recently		Invest regularly			
	P4	P6	P2	P3	P1	P5	Raised by	Verdict
Passed the rule								
Can’t choose between near-identical funds	●	●	●	●	○	●	**5 of 6**	The problem we solve
Didn’t understand the product or the risk	●	●	○	●	●	●	**5 of 6**	Part of the problem
Real, but not the problem								
Left the app to research elsewhere	●	●	○	●	○	●	**4 of 6**	A symptom of it
Bought on news, friends or app suggestions	○	○	●	●	●	○	**3 of 6**	A guardrail
No clear goal or amount in mind	●	●	○	●	○	○	**3 of 6**	Worth watching
Sign-up felt heavy, but nobody quit	○	○	●	●	●	○	**3 of 6**	Friction only
Did not hold up								
Surprised by fees	○	○	○	○	○	○	**0 of 6**	Not a problem here
Free-trade allowance caused a problem	○	○	○	○	○	○	**0 of 6**	Not a problem here

● Raised it ● Raised it, then left the app without buying ○ Did not raise it

Source: 6 student interviews, October 2026. Early evidence, not proof.

Search “S&P 500” and three funds appear, with nothing that says how they differ.



1 Three funds, one index

Vanguard Dist, Vanguard Acc and Amundi Acc all track the S&P 500. Nothing on the screen says so.

2 The only visible difference is jargon

“Dist” and “Acc” decide whether income is paid out or reinvested. There is no explanation.

3 Different prices read as different value

€130, €133 and €137 are prices per unit, not a sign that one fund is better.

4 Three words per fund

“Largest US stocks.” Cost, size and risk are on each fund’s own page, not here.

5 An unrelated company called “S&P”

Further down, CFD versions of S&P 500 funds share near-identical names.

> “The problem wasn’t finding products. It was knowing how to choose between them.”
>
> A student who had never invested, describing this screen

Source: screenshot S40, author’s own account, 19 Oct 2026. Both students who had never invested stopped here and left.

Only one of my starting guesses held up, and in a narrower form than I wrote it.

WHAT I GUESSED BEFORE THE INTERVIEWS	VERDICT	WHAT THE EVIDENCE SHOWED
Fees surprise people on small first purchases	○ **Not supported**	Nobody was surprised. The order screen shows costs before Submit.
The right funds are hard to find	○ **Not supported**	Everyone who looked found S&P 500 funds with the search bar.
Choosing between the right funds is hard	● **Supported**	5 of 6 struggled; both students who had never invested left at that screen.
The free-trade allowance confuses people	◐ **Weak**	Three could not say their allowance, but it caused nobody a problem.
Sign-up effort makes people quit	○ **Not supported**	Heavy for three students; nobody quit because of it.

Source: 6 student interviews and app walkthrough, Oct 2026. Verdicts use the decision rule on slide 2.

The fix uses facts the app already has: side by side, in plain words, with no ranking.

A “Same index, what’s different?” view appears whenever two or more funds track the same index.

Reuse what exists

Yearly cost, fund size and a risk score already sit on each fund’s page. **The view puts them together** at the moment of choice.

Translate the jargon

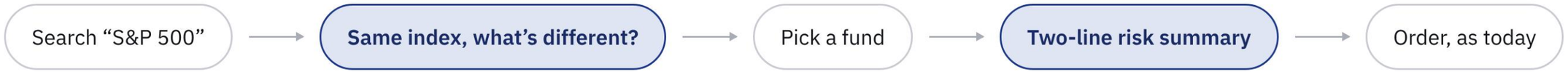
“Dist” and “Acc” become **income paid out** and **income reinvested**. Every row explains itself in one line.

Inform, never advise

Alphabetical order, no “best” badge, no ranking. Under EU rules a personal recommendation is advice; **neutral facts generally are not**.

Risk in two lines

Before a first order: **what you could lose** and how to take money out. Final wording from compliance.



Out of scope on purpose: fees, the free-trade allowance, sign-up, robo-advice, and anything that names a “best” fund.

Source: PRD v1.1. Advice boundary: ESMA guidance via law-firm summaries, checked 19 Oct 2026; legal review still needed.

Success means more confident first purchases without more trading, tested first with a prototype.

PRIMARY METRIC

Of students who open a broad index fund, the share who place a first order within 7 days.

Baseline: to be measured. Target set from the baseline before the test; none invented here.

GUARDRAILS FOR FIRST-TIME INVESTORS

Must not rise	Trades per month
Must not rise	Share of single-stock or leveraged buys
Must not rise	Fee complaints and withdrawals within 30 days

HOW IT WOULD BE TESTED

1. **Prototype, about a week.** 5 to 8 students outside a finance society try the “€50 for ten years” task.
2. **Controlled experiment** in the EEA, control versus view, long enough to see 7-day first orders.
3. **Go or stop.** Go only if the metric beats a pre-agreed minimum and no guardrail worsens.

What this cannot prove yet: six young students, five on Revolut, two in a finance society. No access to Revolut data. The deeper cause may be “no goal”, which the prototype tests.

Source: PRD v1.1, sections 5, 9 and 10.